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The Liberal Party of Canada has found much success by positioning itself in the political centre. They have formed many governments throughout Canadian history with ten prime ministers and in the October 2015 election rose to the top in the House of Commons with a majority government under Justin Trudeau. In the 2019 election they won a minority government.

Before Confederation

The Liberal Party of Canada originated from parties in Nova Scotia (1758), Prince Edward Island (1773), New Brunswick (1784), and Upper and Lower Canada (1791) in opposition to the oligarchs who controlled the colonial governments.

The Parti Canadien was formed at the turn of the 19th century, they were an alliance of French Canadian deputies in the elected Legislative Assembly of Lower Canada. Led by Pierre-Stanislas Bédard, they used the assembly to promote the party's authority within the colonial government.

Pierre-Stanislas Bédard (1792 - 1810)

Pierre-Stanislas Bédard was leader of the very first political party in Canadian history and one of the most important political figures. He was elected to the Legislative Assembly of Lower Canada in 1792 as the representative of Northumberland and was uncontested for the leadership from 1804 to 1812. In 1808 he won the seat for the district of Lower Town Québec, and by 1805 he became the leader of the alliance of French Canadian deputies in the Legislative Assembly that would come to be known as the Parti canadien.

He maintained that the appointed Legislative and Executive councils should not run the colony but instead the elected Legislative Assembly. He advocated for a legislative assembly with greater control over the budget of the colony and instead of the governor general the assembly should select the members of the Legislative Council essentially asking for ministerial responsibility. The idea that a Cabinet could only govern if it had the confidence of the elected assembly would become known as responsible government. These beliefs would become the foundation of the Parti canadien.

After the war of 1812 and under the leadership of Louis-Joseph Papineau, they pushed for the elected Legislative Assembly of Lower Canada, which it dominated, to have greater authority, eligibility for appointment to the council and increased ministerial responsibility. By 1826, the party had changed its name to the Parti patriote.

Louis-Joseph Papineau (1815 - 1854)

Louis-Joseph Papineau was elected to the Assembly of Lower Canada in 1809 and rose to leadership of the Parti patriote and Speaker of the Assembly in 1815. He came to see himself as the protector of French Canada's national heritage and led the battle for control of Lower Canada's political institutions. At the beginning of his career he was a moderate who admired British parliamentary institutions, but his views became more radical during the 1820s and his strategy became more obstructionist.

He became increasingly critical of imperial authority and advocated for Lower Canada's independence and following a sweeping electoral victory in 1834, goaded on by revolutionary elements in his party, he increased efforts to halt the political system by intensifying a policy of political obstruction and boycott to force the British government to grant reforms with the intention to transfer power to the representatives of the French Canadians.

Due to its ambitions being forestalled the party became more radical which ultimately led to the failed rebellion in 1837 causing Papineau to flee to the United States and following the failure of the second insurrection he would sail to France in 1839. He was granted amnesty in 1844, would return from exile in 1845, and re-enter politics in 1848. A group of young liberal nationalists would gather around him which would later become the Parti rouge before he would leave politics in 1854.

William Lyon Mackenzie (1828 - 1857)

Elected in 1828 to the House of Assembly for York County, William Lyon Mackenzie led the opposition party in Upper Canada known as the Reformers. In 1834, he was elected the first mayor of the newly created Toronto City Council and by the end of the year he was once again elected to the provincial parliament. Though facing defeat in 1836, by the late fall of 1837 his mind turned to armed revolt.

After a failed rebellion he fled to the US and attempted to continue the rebellion from Navy Island in the Niagara River until his rebel supply ship was sunk and his fellow rebels were captured and executed for treason. He would return to Canada in 1849 following a government pardon and quickly resumed his political career until retiring in 1857.

Joseph Howe (1836 - 1873)

First elected in 1836 to represent Halifax in the Nova Scotia legislature, Joseph Howe joined the executive council in 1840 where he would remain until resigning in 1843. During his time in government he campaigned for responsible government. He would achieve it in 1848 which would pave the way for Confederation in 1867.

Serving as premier of Nova Scotia from 1861 - 63, an insecure majority and persistent attacks from his Conservative political rival hampered his administration. His role as premier ended when the Liberal Party was soundly defeated in the 1863 election which he contested.

In 1869, he ascended to a Cabinet position as president of the Privy Council, by November he became secretary of state for the provinces and by December appointed Superintendent-General of Indian Affairs. He became lieutenant-governor of Nova Scotia in May 1873, though dying in office three weeks later.

Reformers

Holding a majority in the assembly by 1828, the Liberal movement split in the early 1830s with the moderates being led by Robert Baldwin with a commitment to the British empire, British constitution, a hierarchical society and responsible government. The radical reformers wanted

more republican principles. They wanted an economic and social democracy similar to the United States with greater colonial independence.

Rober Baldwin (1829 - 1851) and Louis-Hippolyte LaFontaine (1830 - 1851)

Robert Baldwin entered politics in 1829 as a Reformer and won a seat in the Assembly in a by-election and in 1841 becoming solicitor general. Sir Louis-Hippolyte LaFontaine was elected in 1830 to the Lower Canadian Assembly and would become the leader of the French Canadian Moderate reformers.

An English-French political alliance was formed between the Upper Canada Reformers, under Robert Baldwin, and the Lower Canada Reformers, under Louis-Hippolyte La Fontaine, in order to form a government in 1842 and 1848 in the United Province of Canada and won a responsible government.

In 1849, the Reform Party in Upper Canada split and from it emerged a radical faction known as the Clear Grits. They pushed for representation by population due to a belief that French Canadians had excessive influence in the government. Doing this would have given more seats to the primarily English-speaking Upper Canada to the detriment of French-speaking Lower Canada.

George Brown (1848 - 1867)

Leading the reformers to victory in 1848, he became an Assembly member for Kent in 1851 where he sat as an independent Reformer. In 1853 he supported the idea of representation by population which would give the majority of seats in legislature to Upper Canada.

The moderate Reformers in Lower Canada, now known as the Parti rouge under Antoine-Aimé Dorion, and Conservatives formed a coalition government in 1854 which left the Clear Grits as the opposition. Due to internal strife the Reform regime collapsed and in order to rebuild it Brown brought the Clear Grits over to his side. Though divided on issues like representation by population, under George Brown the Clear Grits and the Parti rouge came together and formed an uneasy alliance under the title of Liberal in 1857 and would stay together until George Brown joined the Great Coalition.

Together with his Conservative rivals they would form the great coalition of 1864 which would seek a federal union of all British provinces or of Upper and Lower Canada. Running in the first federal election in 1867, he was defeated and left parliament.

After Confederation

The Liberals of Ontario, the Reformers in the Maritimes and the Rouges of Quebec joined together after Confederation under the title of Liberal. Though they had minimal success against Sir John A. Macdonald, the Conservative Prime Minister, and his federal coalition they managed to develop a successful provincial organization.

Alexander Mackenzie (1861 -1879)

Actively helping to organize the election of George Brown to the legislative assembly in 1851, Alexander Mackenzie would be elected to the assembly in 1861, elected to the House of Commons in 1867, and named leader of the Liberal opposition in March 1873.

Due to the Pacific Scandal, which involved the acceptance of campaign funds for the contract to build the Canadian Pacific Railway, which caused the downfall of Macdonald's government, he formed the first Liberal government in 1873. Serving as his own minister of public works he attempted to finish building a transcontinental railway on a self-financing basis but met with little public support.

Though laying the groundwork for Canada's modern electoral system, Mackenzie's lack of political vision and a severe economic depression led to Macdonald's reelection in 1878 with a policy of trade protection. He remained party leader for a further 19 months before a threatened party revolt and his own failing health would force him to step down in favour of Edward Blake, though he still held his seat in the House of Commons until his death.

Edward Blake (1867 -1891)

Edward Blake was recruited into politics by George Brown in 1867, sitting in the Federal House of Commons from 1867 - 1891, and becoming leader of the Ontario Liberal Party in 1868, and adamantly opposed Macdonald's National Policy of tariff protection. In 1871 he became the premier of Ontario and succeeded Mackenzie as party leader in 1880 but lost the elections in 1882 and 1887 resigning as leader of the Liberal party and leaving Canadian politics altogether in 1891.

The only Liberal leader until the 21st century to never become prime minister, his lack of success can be attributed to facing John A. MacDonald at the peak of his popularity, as well as being too dominant in parliamentary activity and leaving his colleagues minimal opportunity to display their leadership.

Sir Wilfrid Laurier (1871 - 1919)

Joining the Quebec legislature in 1871, upon Blake's advice in 1887 a reluctant federal Liberal caucus chose Wilfrid Laurier as party leader. They believed him to be too easygoing and too physically weak to be an effective leader. In his home province of Quebec, where he rose to prominence championing the virtues of racial conciliation, he worked to gradually broaden the party's base.

Laurier capitalized on the mishandling of the Manitoba Schools Question by the Conservatives to win the 1896 election with a platform of provincial rights. By copying Macdonald's formula of an accommodation between French and English Canadians, policies of compromise and a nationwide coalition of forces he would go on to win the next three elections. Under Laurier, the more traditional principles of Liberal reformism would be tempered by patronage and pragmatism.

On the organizational back of the Liberal provincial premiers he built his electoral coalition in Canada. Laurier endorsed Clifford Sifton's, his Manitoba minister, audacious policy to settle the West, and despite his caucus having denounced it in the 1880s when Macdonald championed it, he entered into the same kind of transcontinental railway-building collaboration with the Canadian Northern and Grand Trunk.

In 1905, Laurier was successful in adding Alberta and Saskatchewan to the Dominion of Canada. By yielding to pressure from anglophones and Protestants on the educational rights of the Catholic minority he was harshly criticized by French Canadian nationalist. Though winning the 1908 general election, his prestige in Quebec had begun to fade and he faced a somewhat reduced majority.

Laurier's Liberals were distinguished from their Conservative rivals on various principles. In external affairs, rather than adding to the British navy the Liberals created the Royal Canadian Navy. In commercial policy, the long-held Liberal goal of a reciprocal trade agreement with the United States was achieved.

The protection-minded business community, whose support he cultivated, was alienated by this reciprocity, giving Robert Borden's Conservatives a weakness to exploit. In the face of the Conservatives anti-Americanism the Liberals were defeated in the 1911 election.

As leader of the Opposition, he proved to be energetic and vigilant. He relentlessly attacked the Borden government's failures to address the rising cost of living and many other problems. Laurier despaired as the conscription of the First World War virtually destroyed the party by shaking the solidarity of its English-French alliance.

This weakness caused an overwhelming defeat by Borden's Unionist Party in the 1917 general election. He tried to restructure the party and rebuild Canadian Unity after the end of the First World War but died on February 17, 1919.

William Lyon Mackenzie King (1900 - 48)

Starting in the federal Department of Labour in 1900, William Lyon Mackenzie King became Canada's first deputy minister of Labour. In 1919, King assumed leadership of the Liberal party and would go on to be the longest serving prime minister in Canadian history serving from 1921-48 with two periods in 1926 and 1930-35 where they were the opposition. They led the country through the Great Depression then the Second World War.

In 1940 he introduced unemployment insurance to placate Canadians who wanted greater social security from the government. Preferring the government to play a minimal role at home and abroad, King did not play any decisive roles in the postwar era and in 1948 was persuaded to resign as prime minister, dying two years later.

The political longevity of King can be credited to his ability to soften political issues in order to maintain support from ideologically opposed groups like the protectionist manufacturers in central Canada and western free-trade farmers.

King secured strong wartime support in Quebec by attracting Francophone ministers with strong regional power bases into his Cabinet. These connections helped to advance social-welfare programs for voters while placating the business community.

Louis St-Laurent (1941 - 1958)

Approached by Mackenzie King in December 1941 to become minister of Justice, Louis St-Laurent was elected to the House of Commons representing Quebec East in 1942 and secretary of state for external affairs in 1946.

Becoming prime minister in 1948, Louis St-Laurent was hand-picked to be the successor to King and was applauded by the business and bureaucratic elites. During his time as prime minister, Newfoundland formally joined Canada, equalization payments were approved among the provinces and Old-age pensions were extended. Re-elected in 1949 and 1953 with overwhelming majorities, he would face a reversal in public opinion, the Liberals would be defeated in 1957 by John Diefenbaker's Progressive Conservatives. He would retire from public life in 1958.

He was admired by those who worked for him for his decisiveness, sharp mind and patriotism. Though, his dependency on the bureaucracy of Ottawa and disregard for party organization would cause the collapse of the great Liberal alliance that King worked so hard for and would initiate Western Canada's persistent alienation of the Liberal party. Ever since his narrow defeat to John Diefenbaker in 1957 the Liberals have laboured to regain its once high level of support in the West.

Lester B Pearson (1948 - 1967)

Becoming minister of external affairs in September 1948, Lester B Pearson would represent Altamont, Ontario, in the House of Commons. In 1958 he defeated Paul Martin, Sr. to become leader of the Liberal Party. It would take him three elections to win back federal control in 1963. Walter Gordon, his close advisor, was able to build the party organization thanks to his reformist convictions and organizational skills, though it would further alienate the West. Together they managed to raise the party's total seats to 100 during the 1962 general election.

Capitalizing on Diefenbaker's government fumbling over the issue of nuclear weapons, the Liberals would form a minority government with 128 seats taking office in April 1963. Failing to secure a majority in 1965 he would announce his intention to retire in December 1967.

Much was accomplished by Pearson's Liberals in its five years, despite never achieving a majority government, for example creating the Canada Pension Plan, a national medicare program, unified Armed Forces and a distinctive Canadian flag.

Pierre Elliott Trudeau (1965 - 1984)

Joining the federal Liberal Party in 1965, he was elected to parliament in the riding of Mount Royal. Appointed minister of justice in 1967, in this role he decriminalized homosexuality, legalized abortion, and reformed divorce law.

Succeeding Lester Pearson, Pierre Trudeau took over control of the Liberal party in 1968 and won 153 seats to become prime minister. At the heart of his early appeal to the public, known as Trudeaumania, and the animosities English-Canadian voters had for him was his preoccupation with combating the separatist forces of Quebec nationalism, dedication to federalism, as well as his own charisma.

The Front de Libération du Québec (FLQ) crisis in 1970 was the most dramatic event for Trudeau's first government. Trudeau invoked the War Measure Act, which gave the government full power to arrest, detain, and censor, in response to the kidnapping of Pierre Laporte, Quebec cabinet minister, and James Cross, British diplomat, by the FLQ, a militant Quebec independence movement. This caused much controversy over the use of these measures and their effect on liberal democracy.

French Canadians achieved a greater place within the government of Canada and the Liberal party under Trudeau. The Liberal party's strength in central Canada helped it remain in office till 1979 and then again from 1980 to 1984. In 1982, they introduced the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms and "patriated" the Constitution.

With the shifting public opinion towards Trudeau and the Liberals in 1981 and his personal style of politics becoming less effective during difficult economic times, Trudeau announced his intention to retire in 1984.

John Turner (1962 - 1990)

Recruited by Lester Pearson as a Liberal candidate, John Turner was elected to the House of Commons in 1962. In 1968, he ran for the Liberal leadership but lost to Pierre Trudeau. Trudeau appointed him justice minister in 1968, he was transferred to the Department of Finance in 1972.

As Trudeau stepped down as leader in 1984, his former minister of finance, John Turner, succeeded him, defeating runner-up Jean Chrétien. Hoping to capitalize on a brief surge of popularity the Liberals had in public opinion polls he quickly called a general election, though without an adequate platform and an appealing campaign style the party suffered a devastating defeat only winning 40 seats compared to the Conservatives 211 seats.

The party was plagued with ideological and organizational problems for the next four years as the Opposition. In the 1988 election, he ran on a campaign appealing to nationalism, fuelled by the anxiety spawned from the Conservatives' plan to sign a free trade agreement with the United States, winning 82 seats and restoring the Liberal party's position before stepping down as party leader in 1990.

Jean Chrétien (1963 - 2002)

Representing St-Maurice-Laflèche as a Liberal in the House of Commons in 1963, Jean Chrétien would later become minister of national revenue. Under Pierre Trudeau, Chrétien was moved around to a number of positions including justice; indigenous affairs; treasury board; finance; industry, trade and commerce; and energy, mines and resources.

Winning the leadership in 1990 defeating Paul Martin. Inheriting an almost bankrupt and disorganized party his opposition of the Meech Lake Accord and support of the Conservatives' Charlottetown Accord was detrimental to the Liberals in Quebec.

By focusing on organization and policy development they were prepared for the 1993 election. With a campaign that emphasized job creation and effectively tackling criticisms they won a clear majority of 177 seats. The diminishing power of the Progressive Conservative Party and the NDP, as well as the growth of the Bloc Québécois meant that the Liberal party was the only national party to have representation from every province in the House of Commons; and because of this, in 1997 and 2000, they were re-elected with majorities.

Led by the Finance Minister, Paul Martin, the Chrétien Liberals sought to balance the federal budget and face Canada's high national debt, high taxes and an alarming annual deficit. At the cost of cuts to social programs and provincial transfer payments they eliminated 42 billion in federal deficit and registered its first surplus in 30 years.

Chrétien was confident that he was providing a good government and that this would effectively answer calls for Quebec sovereignty; he largely ignored Quebec nationalists, but he would come to see the flaw in his approach in the 1995 Quebec referendum.

The federal side won the referendum by the narrowest of margins, and in response he would introduce the Clarity Act, which meant that Quebec's separation would only be negotiated after a strong majority voted yes in a referendum with a clear question. Accusations of incompetence and corruption arose in 2002 relating to the misuse of government funds in order to sponsor events in Québec. Fearing the loss of a confidence vote during the Liberal convention, Chrétien announced he would be stepping down in 2002.

Paul Martin (1988 - 2006)

Entering politics in 1988, Paul Martin ran against Jean Chrétien in 1990 for leader of the Liberal party. After the 1993 election he was appointed finance minister. To combat the deep recession of 1994 he cut funding for unemployment insurance as well as closing several military bases. Furthermore, in 1995 he eliminated 45,000 public service jobs, reduced government expenditure by over \$25 billion in the course of three years, and slashing \$7 billion in federal transfer payments to the provinces for health and education. By 1998, he had erased the \$42 billion deficit.

Becoming party leader and prime minister in 2003, he promised to address what he dubbed the country's "democratic deficit" by increasing ordinary MPs power, he promised to strengthen health care, reduce poverty among indigenous people, and improve Canada's position in international affairs. A scandal about the misuse of federal advertising funds in Quebec during the Chrétien years besieged his government and he appointed the Gomery Commission to investigate it in order to distance himself from the affair.

The Gomery Commission's report exonerated Martin of any wrongdoings but it confirmed allegations of corruption in the federal Liberal Party's Quebec wing. After the defeat in the January 2006 election, Martin announced his retirement as party leader.

Though floundering on international issues and often criticized for coming off as indecisive by trying to pursue multiple priorities, Martin's Liberals succeeded on other fronts like legalizing same-sex marriage, forging the Kelowna Accord to improve the quality of life for Indigenous peoples, creating a national child care program, and negotiating a \$41 billion health care accord with the provinces.

Stéphane Dion (1996 - Present)

Serving as president of the Privy Council and minister of intergovernmental affairs, with responsibility for national unity from 1996 to 2003, Stéphane Dion played a critical role in the discussion of Quebec's separation from Canada.

Cabinet minister Stéphane Dion was appointed leader of the Liberal party in December of 2006, and inherited a dispirited and disorganized party in debt after years of internal strife between the Chrétian and Martin camps. An election was called for October 2008 and the centrepiece of the campaign, the "Green Shift", being a promise to lower income taxes and raise a carbon tax on emissions. The Liberals were reduced from 95 to 77 seats in the House of Commons after failing to gain public support and Dion announced his resignation as party leader in October of 2008.

Winning his seat in the House of Commons once more in the 2015 federal election, he was appointed to the Cabinet of Justin Trudeau becoming minister of foreign affairs and chair of the Cabinet Committee on the Environment, Climate Change and Energy.

Michael Ignatieff (2006 - 2013)

Elected to Parliament in January 2006, the Liberal party moved quickly to find a replacement for Dion and installed Michael Ignatieff as the new leader in 2009. In March 2011, in a gamble to force an election and bring down Steven Harper's minority government they combined with other opposition parties but were upstaged during the campaign by the NDP leader Jack Layton resulting in Ignatieff losing his seat.

Capturing a majority government, the Conservatives won the election with the Liberals finishing in third place, only winning 34 seats and having the worst outcome in the party's history. The next day, Ignatieff announced he would step down as leader and later in the month Bob Rae would become interim leader. The once dominant federal party would begin a period of soul-searching about the weaknesses that had reduced them to a third-place position.

Justin Trudeau (2007 - Present)

Winning the Liberal Party nomination in Papineau in 2007 and 2011, Justin Trudeau won the leadership of the Liberal party in 2013 in a landslide vote. There were doubts that he was inexperienced and too young to be prime minister. He overcame these doubts by promising to invest in the economy and new spending, he became a figure of change for voters wanting an end to Stephen Harper's Conservative leadership. Trudeau won a majority government in the 2015 election.

The Trudeau government cut the personal income tax rate on middle-income earners while increasing the rate on wealthier earners, revised the Canada Pension Plan raising contribution rates and reducing the overall tax savings for many but with increased benefits for retirees, Senate reforms, created the Canada Child Benefit for low and middle income families, implemented a \$55 billion 10-year National Housing strategy, legalized marijuana, legalized assisted dying in certain circumstances, and launched the National Inquiry into Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women and Girls.

In 2019, in order to combat climate change, the federal carbon tax came into effect for Manitoba, New Brunswick, Ontario and Saskatchewan as their governments had not created a carbon pricing plan of their own. Criticism has been levered by environmental activists against the Liberals for their approval of the Trans Mountain Expansion Project which would increase exports from the Alberta oil sands.

Foreign affairs presented significant challenges for the Liberals particularly with the United States, China, India and Saudi Arabia have presented significant challenges. Trudeau had a positive relationship with American President Barack Obama but interactions with President Trump strained the relationship between Canada and the United States.

In the 2019 federal election Trudeau's Liberals won a minority government. The party lost support in every province, especially Alberta and Saskatchewan which didn't elect a single Liberal MP. Only receiving 33 per cent compared to the 34 percent of the Conservatives, they also lost the popular vote. Though, with 157 seats in total they help a relatively strong minority government.

Throughout the last two centuries, the Liberal party has played a crucial role in Canadian history. The Parti Canadien and the Parti patriote fought for responsible government. The nascent Liberals collaborated with Conservatives to bring about Confederation. The party has been guided by popular leaders like Sir Wilfrid Laurier and William Lyon Mackenzie King, as well as polarizing individuals like Pierre and Justin Trudeau. The Party has enjoyed great successes, weathered failures and scandals but continues to thrive well into the twenty-first century.

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